

■ STUDY BEES ■

NOVELLA

The Pearl

by

John Steinbeck

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About the Novella

The Pearl is a short novella by the American writer John Steinbeck, first published in 1947. It is based on a Mexican folk tale Steinbeck heard while travelling in La Paz, and it is written in a simple, parable-like style, complete with a brief introductory note that frames the story as a kind of moral fable in which everyone may take away their own meaning.

The story follows Kino, a poor pearl-diving fisherman, whose discovery of an enormous pearl transforms his family's quiet life into one marked by greed, violence and tragedy. Steinbeck uses the novella to explore the destructive power of wealth and the injustice faced by the poor at the hands of a colonial, class-divided society.

Characters

Protagonist

Kino — A poor, proud pearl diver, deeply devoted to his family. The discovery of the great pearl awakens ambitions for a better future, but also suspicion, pride and violence, ultimately changing him from a contented man into someone hardened by loss.

Deuteragonist

Juana — Kino's wife, calm, practical and spiritually grounded. She senses the pearl's danger from the start and represents wisdom and restraint against Kino's growing obsession.

Coyotito — The infant son whose scorpion sting begins the story and whose fate at its end delivers its central tragedy.

Antagonists / Antagonistic Forces

The Doctor — Refuses to treat Coyotito because the family is poor, then manipulates the situation once he learns of the pearl; he embodies the greed and racism of the colonial elite.

The Pearl Buyers — Corrupt town dealers who conspire to underpay Kino, representing organised economic exploitation of the poor.

The Trackers — Armed men sent to steal the pearl, the direct agents of the story's final violence. As in the play, the pearl itself operates as a symbolic antagonist, awakening greed in all who encounter it.

Other Characters

- **Juan Tomás** — Kino's brother, offering shelter and guidance, and voicing concern for the family's safety.
- **Apolonia** — Juan Tomás's wife.
- **The Priest** — Visits Kino once news of the pearl spreads, suggesting the church's own interest in the family's new wealth.
- **The Townspeople** — Their gossip and envy spread word of the pearl and heighten the danger surrounding Kino's family.

Summary

Kino, Juana and their baby Coyotito live a simple life in a brush hut by the Gulf of California, where Kino earns a modest living diving for pearls. When a scorpion stings Coyotito, the family seeks help from the town doctor, who refuses to treat a baby whose parents cannot pay. Determined to find a way to help his son, Kino dives further than usual and discovers an immense pearl, which he names the 'Pearl of the World,' believing it will bring wealth, dignity and opportunity — an education for Coyotito, a church wedding for himself and Juana, and freedom from poverty.

Word of the pearl spreads through the town. The doctor arrives uninvited to 'treat' Coyotito, secretly worsening his condition so he can later claim credit for curing him. When Kino takes the pearl to be valued, the town's pearl buyers — secretly working together for a single unseen master buyer — try to convince him it is worthless, offering an unfairly low price. Kino refuses to sell and resolves to travel to the capital to find a fair buyer, a decision that marks him as a target.

That night an intruder attacks Kino in search of the pearl; he fights the man off but is wounded. Soon after, his canoe is deliberately destroyed and his house is burned down. Fearing further violence, the family flees toward the mountains. Juana repeatedly urges Kino to throw the pearl away, but he refuses, now driven by pride and a stubborn belief that the pearl is his one chance at a better life. Trackers pursue them into the mountains, and when they camp near a spring, Kino, discovered, kills the trackers in a desperate fight after they fire toward the cave where Juana and Coyotito are hiding — but in the chaos, Coyotito is killed.

Grief-stricken, Kino and Juana walk back into the town together in silence, carrying their dead son. At the shore, Kino looks at the pearl one last time, now seeing in it only images of greed, violence and death, and throws it back into the sea, letting the story end where it began.

Plot Structure

Exposition

Steinbeck introduces Kino's peaceful, simple life with Juana and Coyotito, establishing the family's poverty and quiet contentment before misfortune strikes.

Inciting Incident

Coyotito is stung by a scorpion, and the doctor's refusal to treat him without payment exposes the family's helplessness and pushes Kino toward the pearl bed in search of a solution.

Rising Action

Kino discovers the great pearl, and news of it spreads, triggering a chain of escalating dangers: the doctor's manipulation, the buyers' attempted swindle, a violent night attack, the burning of Kino's house, the destruction of his canoe, and the family's desperate flight into the mountains.

Climax

Cornered in a mountain cave, Kino fights and kills the trackers who have been sent to steal the pearl, in the novella's most violent and intense moment.

Anticlimax / Tragic Turn

The seeming triumph over the trackers is instantly undercut: Coyotito has been killed by a stray shot during the fight, transforming victory into devastating loss.

Falling Action

Kino and Juana, carrying their dead child, make the long, silent journey back down from the mountains to the town by the sea.

Denouement and Resolution

Walking together to the shoreline, Kino offers the pearl to Juana, but ultimately throws it into the sea himself, rejecting the wealth that cost him his son and restoring, in sorrow, the story's original world of poverty and simplicity.

Themes

- **The Corrupting Power of Wealth:** the pearl transforms Kino from a contented, loving man into one consumed by ambition, suspicion and violence.
- **Greed and Human Nature:** nearly everyone who learns of the pearl — the doctor, the buyers, the trackers, even the priest — is driven by the desire to possess or profit from it.
- **Poverty, Colonialism and Social Injustice:** the town's treatment of Kino's family reflects the exploitation of indigenous, poor communities by a wealthier colonial class.
- **Fate versus Free Will:** the novella repeatedly questions whether Kino's tragedy was inevitable once he found the pearl, or the result of his own choices to keep and defend it.
- **Family, Love and Loss:** the bond between Kino, Juana and Coyotito anchors the story emotionally, and its destruction delivers its central tragedy.
- **Materialism versus Simplicity:** the novella contrasts the promise of material wealth with the deeper, irreplaceable value of family and a simple, peaceful life.
- **Song / Oral Storytelling Motif:** Steinbeck frames key moments through Kino's inner 'songs' (the Song of the Family, the Song of Evil, the Song of the Pearl), tying the novella to its origins as a folk tale.

Literary Devices

- **Symbolism:** the pearl represents both hope and corrupting greed; the scorpion symbolises the sudden intrusion of misfortune; Kino's canoe symbolises his family's livelihood and tradition.
- **Parable / Allegory:** Steinbeck explicitly frames the story as a parable in his preface, inviting readers to draw their own moral meaning.
- **Foreshadowing:** Juana's early unease about the pearl, and recurring references to 'evil' music in Kino's mind, hint at the coming tragedy.
- **Motif of 'Songs':** recurring internal 'songs' (of the family, of evil, of the pearl) act as a musical motif reflecting Kino's shifting emotional state.
- **Irony:** the pearl, found to secure the family's safety and future, instead brings violence and the death of the child it was meant to help.

- **Imagery:** vivid natural imagery — the sea, the pearl's glow, the darkness of the mountains — reinforces the novella's shifting tone from peace to menace.
- **Contrast:** the simplicity of Kino's brush house is set against the comfort of the town and the doctor's home, underlining social inequality.

SLO-Based Questions & Answers

Q: Who wrote the novella *The Pearl*, and when was it published?

Ans: John Steinbeck, first published in 1947.

Q: What is the source of the story Steinbeck adapted into *The Pearl*?

Ans: A Mexican folk tale he heard while travelling in La Paz.

Q: Why does the doctor initially refuse to treat Coyotito?

Ans: Because Kino and Juana are poor and cannot pay him, reflecting the doctor's greed and prejudice.

Q: What does Kino discover while diving, and what does he call it?

Ans: An enormous, flawless pearl, which he calls the 'Pearl of the World.'

Q: What are the 'songs' that recur in Kino's mind throughout the novella?

Ans: Internal songs such as the Song of the Family, the Song of Evil, and the Song of the Pearl, which reflect his shifting emotions.

Q: How do the pearl buyers try to cheat Kino?

Ans: They act together, secretly working for one master buyer, and try to convince Kino the pearl is worthless so they can purchase it cheaply.

Q: Why does Juana want Kino to get rid of the pearl?

Ans: Because she senses from early on that it will bring only violence and destroy the family's peace.

Q: What violent events occur as a result of the pearl becoming known in town?

Ans: Kino is attacked at night, his canoe is destroyed, and his house is burned down by people seeking the pearl.

Q: Why does the family flee into the mountains?

Ans: To escape armed trackers sent to steal the pearl after earlier attempts to take it failed.

Q: What is the climax of the novella?

Ans: Kino's violent fight with the trackers in a mountain cave after they discover the family's hiding place.

Q: What tragic event happens immediately after the climax?

Ans: Coyotito is killed by a stray shot during the confrontation with the trackers.

Q: How does the novella end?

Ans: Kino and Juana return to the shore together, and Kino throws the pearl back into the sea, rejecting the wealth that destroyed his family's happiness.

Q: What does the pearl symbolise in the story?

Ans: Both the hope of a better life and the corrupting, destructive power of greed and material wealth.

Q: What broader social issue does the novella highlight through the doctor and pearl buyers?

Ans: The exploitation and injustice faced by poor, indigenous communities under a wealthier, colonial class.

Q: What is the central theme of The Pearl?

Ans: That the pursuit of wealth, when driven by greed, can corrupt human nature and destroy what matters most — family, love and peace.